

Repo Layout, Tooling, Deployment & Helix-Ecosystem Integration

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Revision: 1 **Last modified:** 2026-06-25T00:00:00Z **Status:** active — subordinate to SPECIFICATION.md (the spine). Where this document disagrees with the spine on roles, principles (spine §4), or the decision register (spine §9), the spine wins until amended per §11.4.73. **Authority:** This document owns the **physical engineering substrate** of HelixVPN: the working monorepo, the decoupled reusable-component repos, schema-first codegen, the `helixvpnctl` operator CLI, the three deployment substrates (Podman quadlets / Docker Compose / Kubernetes), and the wiring of every already-incorporated submodules/ member into its concrete role. It is a **specification**, not the product — interface sketches, manifests, and skeletons are illustrative, not the shipping implementation (2–3 refinement passes follow). **Evidence base:** [04_ARCH §4/§9/§10/§11] = 04_VPN_CLD/HelixVPN-Architecture-Refined.md; [04_P1] = HelixVPN-Phase1-MVP.md; [04_P0] = HelixVPN-Phase0-Spike.md; [04_UI] = HelixVPN-helix-ui-Flutter.md; [05_YB0] = mandated-stack brief; [SYNTHESIS] = v09-research/_SYNTHESIS.md; per-LLM ids [02_QWN] [01_DSK] [07_GMI] [10_KMI] [11_MST]; [research-podman_k8s] = the Podman-Quadlet / podman kube / Kubernetes-for-WireGuard deep-research thread (verified against latest official sources per §11.4.99).

0. How to read this document

This document maps the *logical* architecture (data plane → doc 01, control plane → doc 02, client core + UI → doc 03, security/PKI → doc 04) onto **files, repos, build tools, and deploy units**. Three things are settled and load-bearing here:

1. **Reuse pillars** — three reusable cores (Rust transport/VPN, Flutter UI, schema-generated clients) shared by all roles and apps [04_ARCH §5/§11, SYNTHESIS §6].
2. **Decoupling target** — each reuse pillar becomes its own *vasic-digital* repo per §11.4.28/.29/.74, but **only after the spec stabilizes** (this is sequenced below, not done eagerly).
3. **Rootless-first deploy** — Podman quadlets are the *canonical* substrate (§11.4.76/.161); Compose and Kubernetes are *equivalents* for operators on those substrates, generated from the same OCI images.

Conventions: **MUST** / **SHOULD** / **MAY** carry RFC 2119 force. Open choices live in §12 (**Decision callouts**) as options + recommendation per §11.4.66/.101 — never silently resolved.

1. Two-repo-shape strategy: build in a monorepo, extract reusable repos later

1.1 The tension and the resolution

The constitution wants **decoupled, reusable, project-not-aware components** each in its own repo (§11.4.28/.74). The MVP wants **velocity and atomic cross-cutting changes** (one PR touches proto + Go + Rust + Dart). These pull in opposite directions only if treated as simultaneous; they are not. The resolution, recommended and binding for this spec:

Phase 0 → Phase 1: one working monorepo helixvpn/ with internal workspace boundaries that are *already* the future repo boundaries. **Post-MVP (Phase 1 exit gate):** extract the six stabilized pillars into standalone vasic-digital repos and re-consume them as flat submodules. Nothing is extracted before its public surface stops churning (§11.4.124 — don't split before you know the seams).

This mirrors the control-plane "one Go binary, many packages; package boundaries == future service boundaries" discipline [04_ARCH §4.1] applied at the *repository* level. It satisfies §11.4.28 (the boundaries exist from day one; they are merely co-located until stable) without paying the multi-repo coordination tax during the highest-churn phase.

flowchart LR

```
subgraph P0["Phase 0-1 – monorepo helixvpn/"]
  A[helix-core/ Rust]:::r
  B[helix-edge/ Rust]:::r
  C[helix-go/ Go]:::g
  D[helix-proto/ schema]:::s
  E[helix-ui/ Flutter]:::f
  F[deploy/ quadlets+ctl]:::d
end
subgraph P2["Phase 1 exit → decoupled vasic-digital repos"]
  A2[(helix_core)]:::r
  B2[(helix_edge)]:::r
  C2[(helix_control)]:::g
  D2[(helix_proto)]:::s
  E2[(helix_ui)]:::f
  F2[(helix_deploy)]:::d
end
A -.extract when stable.-> A2
B -.-> B2
C -.-> C2
D -.extract FIRST (most stable).-> D2
E -.-> E2
F -.-> F2
```

```

classDef r fill:#7d3cff22,stroke:#7d3cff;
classDef g fill:#00add822,stroke:#00add8;
classDef s fill:#ff9d0022,stroke:#ff9d00;
classDef f fill:#02569b22,stroke:#02569b;
classDef d fill:#33333322,stroke:#666;

```

1.2 Extraction order (most-stable-first)

Order	Monorepo dir	Extracted repo (vasic-digital)	Why this order
1	helix-proto/	helix_proto	The schema is the contract; it must stabilize first so generated clients stop drifting. Extract at the first frozen WatchNetworkMap version [04_P1 §3].
2	helix-core/	helix_core	The Transport trait + FFI surface survive Phase 0 by design [04_P0]; extract once iOS memory gate G3 passes and the FFI ABI freezes.
3	helix-edge/	helix_edge	Depends on helix_core (helix-transport); extract right after it.
4	helix-ui/	helix_ui	Design system + Riverpod-over-status-stream contract stable by MVP DoD [04_UI].
5	helix-go/	helix_control	Largest churn surface (policy compiler, coordinator); extract last among code.
6	deploy/	helix_deploy	Quadlet/Compose/K8s generators + helixvpctl; extract when image names + env contract freeze.

Each extraction is a **visible commit** citing §11.4.35 ("Lifted from helixvpn monorepo to vasic-digital/helix_proto per §11.4.28"), preserves history via `git filter-repo --path helix-proto/`, and immediately re-consumes the new repo as a flat submodule (§1.4).

2. Monorepo layout (helixvpn/) — file-by-file

The canonical tree, with the load-bearing files spelled out. Directory and file names are **lowercase snake_case** where they are ours to name (§11.4.29); language-mandated layouts (Rust crates/, Dart lib/, Cargo/Go file names) follow their ecosystem (§11.4.29 exception).

```

helixvpn/                                     # umbrella working repo
(this repository's product code)
├─ Cargo.toml                               # Rust workspace root –
members: helix-core/crates/*, helix-edge
├─ go.work                                   # Go workspace –
uses ./helix-go (+ extracted submodules later)

```

```

└─ melos.yaml # Dart/Flutter monorepo
manager (helix-ui packages)
└─ buf.yaml buf.gen.yaml buf.lock # schema-first codegen
config (§4)
└─ Makefile # local task runner
(gen / build / test / deploy) – NO CI (§11.4.156)
└─ .gitignore # build
artifacts, .env, *.db-wal/-shm (§11.4.30)
└─ .env.example # HELIX_RELEASE_PREFIX,
infra creds template (§11.4.77/.151)
└─ helix-deps.yaml # submodule dependency
manifest (§11.4.31)
|
└─ helix-proto/ # — reuse pillar 1:
the contract —
|   └─ proto/helix/v1/
|       └─ coordinator.proto # WatchNetworkMap +
NetworkMap + MapDelta [04_P1 §3]
|       └─ enrollment.proto # device enroll / cert
issue / revoke
|       └─ types.proto # Peer, Route,
TransportPolicy, DnsConfig, KillSwitch
|       └─ openapi/helix-rest.v1.yaml # Console/Access/
Connector REST surface [04_ARCH §4.2]
|       └─ gen/ # GENERATED
(gitignored) → go/ dart/ rust/ ts/
|
└─ helix-core/ # — reuse pillar 2a:
Rust client+connector core —
|   └─ Cargo.toml # crate group
|       └─ crates/
|           └─ helix-transport/ # Transport trait +
masque/hysteria2/ss/uot impls [04_P0]
|           └─ helix-wg/ # WireGuard control +
boringtun fallback [SYNTHESIS §2]
|           └─ helix-reconcile/ # network-map
declarative reconciler (diff desired↔actual)
|           └─ helix-netshield/ # kill-switch + DNS-
leak state machine (doc 04 §)
|           └─ helix-ffi/ # flutter_rust_bridge
v2 + UniFFI surface → Dart/Swift/Kotlin
|
└─ helix-edge/ # — reuse pillar 2b:
Rust gateway data-plane edge —
|   └─ Cargo.toml # depends on helix-
core/crates/helix-transport (path dep)
|       └─ src/ # quinn+h3 MASQUE
termination + kernel-WG fast path [04_ARCH §4.7]
|
└─ helix-go/ # — the Go control
plane (modular monolith) —
|   └─ go.mod # module helixvpn/
helix-go
|   └─ cmd/

```

```

|   |   |— helixd/                                # control-plane binary
(all packages wired)
|   |   |— helixvpncctl/                          # operator CLI (Cobra)
- $5
|   |— internal/                                  # identity registry
ipam pki policy coordinator events telemetry api store
|
|— helix-ui/                                       # — reuse pillar 3:
Flutter —
|   |— melos.yaml                                # (or root melos.yaml
governs)
|   |— packages/
|       |— helix_design/                          # Material-3 + brand
tokens, signature components [04_UI]
|       |— helix_core_ffi/                        # Dart bindings to
helix-ffi (generated)
|       |— helix_api_client/                      # generated REST+Connect
client from helix-proto
|       |— app_access/                            # end-user flavor
|       |— app_connector/                        # network-operator
flavor
|       |— app_console/                          # admin flavor
(web+desktop; NO core_ffi)
|
|— shims/                                         # per-platform
TunnelPlatform providers (only platform code)
|   |— apple/                                    # NEPacketTunnelProvider (Swift, UniFFI)
|   |— android/                                # VpnService + JNI (Kotlin)
|   |— windows/                                # wireguard-nt/wintun + privileged service
(named-pipe IPC)
|   |— linux/                                  # kernel WG / tun (Rust)
|   |— harmonyos/                             # Network Kit ability (ArkTS → NAPI → .so)
[Phase 3]
|   |— aurora/                                  # Qt/C++ + tun
[Phase 3]
|
|— deploy/                                       # — deployment
substrate (→ helix_deploy) —
|   |— quadlets/                                # *.pod *.container
*.network *.volume (CANONICAL, §11.4.76)
|   |— compose/docker-compose.yaml             # equivalence target
for Docker operators
|   |— k8s/                                     # Helm-less plain
manifests + kustomize overlays
|   |— terraform/                              # gateway VPS
provisioning (cloud-init → helixvpncctl join)
|   |— grafana/                                # dashboards-as-code
(telemetry counters only)
|
|— submodules/                                  # already-incorporated
Helix ecosystem (§6)
|   |— containers/ docs_chain/ helix_qa/ challenges/
security/
|   |— vision_engine/ llm_orchestrator/ llm_provider/

```

```

llms_verifier/
├── panoptic/  doc_processor/
└── constitution/
submodule (canonical root, §11.4.35) # HelixConstitution

```

2.1 Workspace manifests (skeletons)

Rust workspace (Cargo.toml) — one resolver, shared lockfile, path deps so helix-edge reuses helix-transport byte-for-byte (the D5 "shares helix-transport" property [SYNTHESIS §3]):

```

[workspace]
resolver = "2"
members = [
    "helix-core/crates/helix-transport",
    "helix-core/crates/helix-wg",
    "helix-core/crates/helix-reconcile",
    "helix-core/crates/helix-netshield",
    "helix-core/crates/helix-ffi",
    "helix-edge",
]
[workspace.dependencies]
quinn = "0.11"           # QUIC for MASQUE (h3) - edge + client
h3 = "0.0.6"
boringtun = "0.6"        # userspace WG fallback [SYNTHESIS §2]
tokio = { version = "1", features = ["full"] }

```

Go workspace (go.work) — keeps helixd + helixvpncctl in one module pre-extraction; after extraction the containers/challenges submodules are added via replace directives during dev + pinned SHAs in release (§11.4.76 consumption rule):

```

go 1.24
use ./helix-go
// post-extraction:
// use ./submodules/containers
// replace digital.vasic.containers => ./submodules/containers

```

Melos (melos.yaml) governs the Flutter tree; runHelixApp(flavor, ...) produces all three apps from packages/app_* [04_UI, SYNTHESIS §5]. Console is the only Web build and omits helix_core_ffi.

3. Decoupled reusable-component repos (the §11.4.28/.29/.36/.74 target)

3.1 The six repos and their public contract

Created **after** the spec stabilizes (per §1.2 order). Each is its own GitHub **and** GitLab repo (§2.1 multi-mirror), `snake_case` (§11.4.29), **flat** under the consumer (no nested own-org `.gitmodules` chains — §11.4.28(C)), with an `upstreams/` recipe dir + `install_upstreams` run on clone (§11.4.36).

Repo	Language	Public surface (the only thing consumers depend on)	Consumed by
helix_proto	proto+OpenAPI	proto/helix/v1/*.proto, openapi/helix-rest.v1.yaml; ships generated Go/Dart/Rust/TS as release artifacts	core, edge, control, ui
helix_core	Rust	Transport trait, helix-wg API, helix-ffi C-ABI/UniFFI surface	edge, Access/Connector apps, shims
helix_edge	Rust	gateway data-plane binary + EdgeConfig (no public lib API beyond config)	deploy
helix_control	Go	helixd binary + internal packages stay private; only the binary + its REST/proto contracts are the surface	deploy, helixvpncctl
helix_ui	Dart/Flutter	helix_design package + runHelixApp() entry + Riverpod status-stream contract	the 3 apps
helix_deploy	Go+YAML+HCL	helixvpncctl binary + quadlet/compose/k8s generators	operators

Decoupling invariant (§11.4.28(B)): none of these may hardcode HelixVPN-specific hostnames, asset names, or tenant assumptions. `helix_core` is a generic WG-over-pluggable-transport engine; `helix_proto` is a generic coordination schema; both are reusable by any overlay-network project. Project specifics enter only via **config injection** (env var / config struct / constructor param) — never a hardcoded reach.

3.2 Per-repo scaffold checklist (applied to all six)

<repo>/
├─ README.md CLAUDE.md AGENTS.md GEMINI.md QWEN.md #

```

inherit constitution (§11.4.35/.157)
├─ constitution/                                     #
HelixConstitution submodule
├─ upstreams/                                         # *.sh
recipes: GitHub + GitLab remotes (§11.4.36)
├─ ├── github.sh   gitlab.sh
├─ └─ helix-deps.yaml                                # own-
org Git SSH deps (§11.4.31)
├─ .gitignore   .env.example                         #
§11.4.30/.77
├─ docs/                                              #
Status.md + Status_Summary.md + guides (§11.4.45/.56)
├─ └─ .docs_chain/contexts/<repo>.yaml                #
docs_chain export+DB sync (§11.4.106)
└─ (language tree)

```

helix-deps.yaml for helix_edge (the only code repo with an own-org build-time dep):

```

schema_version: 1
deps:
  - name: helix_core
    ssh_url: git@github.com:vasic-digital/helix_core.git
    ref: main
    why: "helix-edge reuses the helix-transport crate byte-for-
         byte (D5)"
    layout: flat
transitive_handling:
  recursive: true
  conflict_resolution: operator-required
language_specific_subtree: false

```

3.3 Creation procedure (operator-gated, §11.4.66)

Decision D-REPO-CREATE (operator-gated). Remote repo creation (gh repo create / glab repo create on vasic-digital) is high-blast-radius and **cannot** be done autonomously (§11.4.101 block-only rule). The extraction PR is prepared autonomously (filtered history, scaffold, submodule pointer staged); the actual repo-create + first push is surfaced to the operator with the exact gh/glab commands. **Recommended:** create all six in one batch at the Phase-1 exit gate so the release tags share the <PREFIX>- prefix across every repo in one release (§11.4.151).

sequenceDiagram

```

participant Dev as Conductor (autonomous)
participant Op as Operator (gated)
participant GH as GitHub vasic-digital
participant GL as GitLab vasic-digital
Dev->>Dev: git filter-repo --path helix-proto/ (preserve
history)
Dev->>Dev: scaffold §3.2 + constitution submodule + upstreams/
Dev->>Op: AskUserQuestion: create vasic-digital/helix_proto?
[gh+glab cmds]

```



```
Op->>GH: gh repo create vasic-digital/helix_proto
Op->>GL: glab repo create vasic-digital/helix_proto
Dev->>Dev: cd repo && install_upstreams    (configures both
remotes, §11.4.36)
Dev->>GH: push main + helixvpn-X.Y tag (merge-onto-main, no
force §11.4.113)
Dev->>GL: push (cascade, §2.1)
Dev->>Dev: git submodule add (flat) into helixvpn/; bump pointer
(§11.4.26 step 7)
```

4. Schema-first codegen (zero-drift contract)

The single most important anti-drift mechanism: **all** Go/Dart/Rust/TS clients are *generated* from helix-proto; hand-written clients are forbidden so the codebases cannot drift [04_ARCH §4.2, 04_P1 §8].

4.1 buf for protobuf (agent contracts)

```
# buf.yaml
version: v2
modules:
  - path: helix-proto/proto
lint:    { use: [STANDARD] }
breaking: { use: [FILE] }    # breaking-change detector vs the
                             frozen contract

# buf.gen.yaml – Connect (gRPC + gRPC-Web + Connect) so ONE
                             service serves
# native agents over HTTP/2 AND browser clients [04_P1 §3]
version: v2
plugins:
  - remote: buf.build/protocolbuffers/go          ; out: helix-
    proto/gen/go
  - remote: buf.build/connectrpc/go                ; out: helix-
    proto/gen/go
  - remote: buf.build/protocolbuffers/dart          ; out: helix-
    proto/gen/dart
  - remote: buf.build/community/neoeinstein-prost ; out: helix-
    proto/gen/rust    # prost for Rust
  - remote: buf.build/community/neoeinstein-tonic ; out: helix-
    proto/gen/rust
```

Decision D-CODEGEN-NET. buf remote plugins need network. Per §11.4.77 the regeneration mechanism must work from a clean clone.
Recommended: vendor protoc-gen-* plugins as pinned binaries under tools/ (Go tools.go + go install, Rust via cargo install --locked) so make gen runs **offline** after a one-time make gen-tools;
buf generate --template buf.gen.local.yaml points at the local binaries. The remote-plugin form stays as the convenience path.

4.2 OpenAPI for REST (app surface)

openapi/helix-rest.v1.yaml → oapi-codegen (Go server stubs for Gin) + openapi-generator/swagger_dart_code_generator (Dart client for the three apps) [04_P1 §8]. The Console (TS/Web build) consumes the same spec via openapi-typescript.

4.3 The make gen contract (no CI — §11.4.156)

```
gen: gen-proto gen-openapi gen-ffi      ## regenerate ALL clients
    from schema (run before build)
gen-proto:    ; buf generate --template buf.gen.local.yaml
gen-openapi:  ; oapi-codegen -config helix-go/internal/api/
               oapi.cfg.yaml openapi/helix-rest.v1.yaml
gen-ffi:      ; cd helix-core/crates/helix-ffi &&
               flutter_rust_bridge_codegen generate
verify-gen:  gen                          ## §11.4.108 artifact
               check: regen must be a no-op
               @git diff --exit-code helix-proto/gen helix-ui/packages/
               helix_core_ffi \
               || { echo "GENERATED CLIENTS STALE – run make gen"; exit 1; }
```

verify-gen is the **drift gate** (the local equivalent of a CI check, run in the pre-commit hook per §11.4.75): a stale generated client fails the local gate. This is the schema-first guarantee made mechanical.

5. helixvpctl — the operator CLI (Cobra)

Replaces the original deployment doc's pile of bash install scripts with one Go binary [04_ARCH §4.7, 04_P1 §9]. It is the homelab front door (init + systemctl start = a running gateway) and the GitOps front door (policy apply).

5.1 Command tree

```
helixvpctl
├── init                --domain --data-dir [--substrate quadlet|
compose[k8s]          # bootstrap (§5.3)
├── gateway
│   ├── keys            # rotate gateway WG keys
│   └── status          # edge health, transport ladder
├── posture
├── enroll-token       --kind connector|client --site NAME [--
qr]                   # mint enrollment token
├── policy
│   ├── apply          ./policy.jsonc    # dry-run compile → persist →
emit policy.updated (GitOps)
│   └── diff           ./policy.jsonc    # show compiled visibility
delta without applying
└── device
```

```

|   | └─ list
|   | └─ revoke      <id>                # revoke <1s (doc 04)
└─ network          advertise|withdraw --connector ID --cidr CIDR
|   └─ deploy
|       └─ quadlet    --out /etc/containers/systemd/    # render
canonical units (§7.1)
|   └─ compose        --out ./                        # render
docker-compose.yaml (§7.2)
|   └─ kube            --out ./k8s/                    # render
K8s manifests (§7.3)
└─ join              --control URL --token T          # fleet
member joins control plane (Phase 2)

```

5.2 Skeleton (Cobra + cited behavior)

```

// helix-go/cmd/helixvpnctl/main.go (illustrative)
package main

import "github.com/spf13/cobra"

func main() {
    root := &cobra.Command{Use: "helixvpnctl", Short: "HelixVPN
        gateway operator CLI"}
    root.AddCommand(initCmd(), enrollCmd(), policyCmd(),
        deviceCmd(), deployCmd())
    _ = root.Execute()
}

func initCmd() *cobra.Command {
    var domain, dataDir, substrate string
    c := &cobra.Command{Use: "init", Short: "Bootstrap a single-
        node gateway",
        RunE: func(cmd *cobra.Command, _ []string) error {
            // 1. generate tenant + admin user + overlay /48 (or
            // 100.64/10 - D4, doc 01)
            // 2. mint CA root + first gateway WG keypair (doc 04
            // PKI)
            // 3. write Postgres+Redis creds to data-dir (mode
            // 600, §11.4.10)
            // 4. render deploy units for the chosen substrate
            // (default quadlet, §11.4.76)
            // 5. print: `systemctl --user start helixvpn-pod`
            [04_P1 §9]
            return bootstrap(domain, dataDir, substrate)
        }}
    c.Flags().StringVar(&domain, "domain", "", "public gateway
        FQDN (required)")
    c.Flags().StringVar(&dataDir, "data-dir", "/var/lib/
        helixvpn", "")
    c.Flags().StringVar(&substrate, "substrate", "quadlet",
        "quadlet|compose|k8s")
    _ = c.MarkFlagRequired("domain")
    return c
}

```

5.3 init artifact set (what a fresh init writes)

flowchart TD

```
I["helixvpnctl init --domain gw.example.com"] --> T[tenant + admin]
I --> CA["CA root + gateway WG keypair (doc 04)"]
I --> CR["Postgres/Redis creds → data-dir (0600, §11.4.10)"]
I --> OV["overlay allocation: ULA /48 or 100.64/10 (D4, doc 01)"]
I --> U{substrate?}
U -->|quadlet| Q["/etc/containers/systemd/helixvpn.{pod,container,network}"]
U -->|compose| DC[./docker-compose.yaml + .env]
U -->|k8s| K8[./k8s/*.yaml]
Q --> R["systemctl --user start helixvpn-pod"]
```

6. Helix-ecosystem submodule integration (the part the research pre-dates)

The 16 source docs were written *before* submodules/ was incorporated; the master spec MUST wire each in or mark not-applicable with reason [SYNTHESIS §8]. Below is the binding map. Submodules are **consumed by reference** (§11.4.106/.80 pattern) — never copied, never given HelixVPN-specific code (§11.4.28(B)).

6.1 Role map

Submodule	Module / kind	HelixVPN role	Binding §
containers	digital.vasic.containers (Go)	Sole container-orchestration layer: helixvpnctl deploy boot/health/compose primitives and on-demand integration-test infra (boot Postgres+Redis+gateway for e2e, tear down)	§11.4.76/.161
challenges	digital.vasic.challenges (Go)	Challenge engine underpinning anti-bluff acceptance Challenges (MVP DoD as executable Challenges)	§11.4.27/.5/.69
helix_qa	HelixQA (Go)	Anti-bluff QA orchestrator: drives the 8 MVP-DoD acceptance criteria with captured evidence; crash detection; ticket generation	§11.4.27/.107/.

Submodule	Module / kind	HelixVPN role	Binding §
docs_chain	vasic-digital/docs_chain (Go)	Mechanical sync of this spec set (final/*. md → HTML/PDF/DOCX) and the workable-items SQLite DB [?] docs	§11.4.106/.65/.1
security	digital.vasic.security (Go)	Control-plane defensive libs: PII redaction in logs (keep no-logging honest), HTTP security headers on REST, AES-256-GCM at-rest for the data-dir secrets, SSRF-deny on outbound, privesc scan of the edge container	§7 (doc 04)
vision_engine	VisionEngine (Go)	Video/screenshot evidence analysis for Flutter UI Challenges (connect-flow recordings → OCR/state verify)	§11.4.107/.158
panoptic	Panoptic (Go)	UI automation + screenshot/video capture harness feeding vision_engine (web+desktop+mobile app drive)	§11.4.107/.154
doc_processor	DocProcessor (Go)	Feature-map extraction from this spec → the per-feature Status ledger (§11.4.153) coverage cross-check	§11.4.153
llm_provider	digital.vasic.llmprovider (Go)	Provider abstraction (circuit-breaker/retry) iff any LLM-assisted op ships (e.g. natural-language policy authoring). Not in the packet/control path.	§11.4.74
llm_orchestrator	digital.vasic.llmorchestrator (Go)	Headless CLI-agent orchestration for the <i>development</i> loop (subagent QA), not a product runtime dependency	§11.4.70
llms_verifier	LLMsVerifier (Go)	Verifies any LLM the dev loop uses ("do you see my code?" gate); not a HelixVPN runtime component	§11.4.78

6.2 Not-applicable / dev-only justifications (§11.4.6, no silent drop)

- **llm_orchestrator, llms_verifier** — **dev-loop only**. HelixVPN ships no LLM in its data or control path; these support the autonomous build/QA loop (subagent dispatch, model verification). They are correctly present as submodules (the project uses them to *build* itself) but are **not** linked into helixd/helix-edge. Marking them runtime-N/A is the honest classification, not an omission.
- **llm_provider** — **conditional**. Only binds if Phase-2 ships LLM-assisted policy authoring (a Console convenience: "natural language → Tailscale-ACL"). If that feature is cut, llm_provider stays dev-only. Surfaced as **Decision D-LLM-POLICY** (§12).
- **vision_engine / panoptic** — **test-infra, not product**. They validate the Flutter apps' user-visible flows with captured video evidence per §11.4.107/.159; they never ship inside an app bundle.

6.3 containers submodule — the canonical deploy + test-infra seam

containers is the **only** sanctioned path to docker/podman/k8s from this project (§11.4.76 — no ad-hoc docker/podman commands outside pkg/boot/pkg/compose/pkg/health). Two concrete uses:

(A) On-demand integration-test infra (the §11.4.76 on-demand-infra invariant — operators never podman machine by hand; the test entry point boots infra):

```
// helix-go/internal/store/integration_test.go (illustrative)
import (
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/boot"
    "digital.vasic.containers/pkg/health"
)

func TestWatchNetworkMapDeltaStream(t *testing.T) {
    ctx := context.Background()
    infra := boot.Compose(ctx, boot.Spec{                                //
        rootless Podman (§11.4.161)
        Services: []boot.Service{
            {Name: "pg", Image: "docker.io/library/postgres:16", Port: 5432},
            {Name: "redis", Image: "docker.io/library/redis:7", Port: 6379},
        },
    })
    t.Cleanup(func() { infra.Down(ctx) })                                //
        §11.4.14 quiescent teardown
    health.WaitReady(ctx, infra,
        30*time.Second)           // not a sleep – real readiness
        probe
    // ... drive enroll → advertise → policy → assert MapDelta
        [04_P1 §11.1]
}
```

This is anti-bluff-critical (§11.4.76(5)): an integration test claiming to exercise the streamed WatchNetworkMap **MUST** actually boot Postgres+Redis via the submodule — a short-circuit fake that skips boot is a §11.4 violation.

(B) Deploy generation — `helixvpncctl deploy {quadlet,compose,kube}` renders manifests through `containers/pkg/compose` primitives so the three substrates derive from one in-code spec rather than three hand-maintained files (§11.4.81 cross-platform-parity: one source, per-substrate render).

6.4 docs_chain — spec + workable-items sync

This very document set is a `docs_chain` corpus. The consumer context lives at `.docs_chain/contexts/helixvpn_spec.yaml` and declares: each `final/*.md` → `.html/.pdf/.docx` (§11.4.65/.153 four-format), the workable-items SQLite DB (§11.4.93/.95) [\[?\]](#) a generated `docs/Issues.md` view, and content-hash change detection (§11.4.86, not mtime). The engine is invoked by `make docs-sync` and verified by `make docs-verify` (the deterministic gate, §11.4.106(C)).

```
# .docs_chain/contexts/helixvpn_spec.yaml (illustrative)
version: 1
nodes:
  - id: spec-00..05
    glob: docs/research/mvp/final/*.md
    transforms:
      - exec: "pandoc {src} -o {src%.md}.html"
      - exec: "weasyprint {src%.md}.html {src%.md}.pdf"
      - exec: "pandoc {src} -o {src%.md}.docx" # §11.4.153
        DOCX adds to the export set
  - id: workable-items
    sync:
      - left: docs/.workable_items.db # git-tracked
        SSoT (§11.4.95)
        right: docs/Issues.md
        authority: db # DB wins; doc
          is a view
```

7. Deployment substrates (three, one image set)

All three substrates run the **same** OCI images (`helixd`, `helix-edge`, plus stock `postgres/redis`). Podman quadlets are **canonical** (§11.4.76/.161); Compose and K8s are **equivalents** for operators on those runtimes [`research-podman_k8s`]. The data-plane edge needs `NET_ADMIN` + `UDP/443` (MASQUE) + kernel WG; everything else is unprivileged.

flowchart LR

```
IMG["OCI images: helixd, helix-edge, postgres:16, redis:7"]
IMG --> Q["Podman quadlets (CANONICAL §11.4.76)"]
IMG --> C["Docker Compose (equivalence)"]
IMG --> K["Kubernetes (fleet/cloud)"]
Q --> H["homelab / single VPS (recommended self-host)"]
C --> H2["operators on Docker today"]
K --> F["multi-region fleet, Phase 2 HA"]
```

7.1 Podman quadlets (canonical, rootless)

The pod groups edge + control + Postgres + Redis for single-node self-host [04_P1 §9.2]. helixvpctl init writes these; systemctl --user start helixvpn-pod runs them — **rootless, no Docker daemon** (§11.4.161).

```
# /etc/containers/systemd/helixvpn.pod
[Pod]
PodName=helixvpn
PublishPort=443:443/udp      # MASQUE/QUIC ingress
PublishPort=51820:51820/udp  # plain-WG ingress (auto-ladder
                             base, doc 01)

# /etc/containers/systemd/helix-edge.container — DATA PLANE
                             (Phase-0 G4 winner)
[Unit]
Description=HelixVPN data-plane edge
[Container]
Image=ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helix-edge:1.0
Pod=helixvpn.pod
AddCapability=NET_ADMIN      # ONLY this; drop the rest (doc 04
                             §)
ReadOnly=true                # read-only rootfs (§11.4 security
                             invariant)
SecurityLabelType=helixvpn_edge.process # seccomp/SELinux
                             confinement
# no SSH, no shell in this image
[Install]
WantedBy=default.target

# /etc/containers/systemd/helixd.container — CONTROL PLANE
[Container]
Image=ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helixd:1.0
Pod=helixvpn.pod
Environment=DATABASE_URL=postgres://helix_app@localhost/helix #
                             non-superuser → RLS enforced (doc 02)
Environment=REDIS_URL=redis://localhost:6379
Secret=helix_db_pw,type=env,target=PGPASSWORD                  #
                             podman secret, never in unit text
ReadOnly=true
NoNewPrivileges=true

# /etc/containers/systemd/helix-pg.container (redis analogous)
[Container]
Image=docker.io/library/postgres:16
Pod=helixvpn.pod
Volume=helix-pgdata.volume:/var/lib/postgresql/data:Z
Environment=POSTGRES_USER=helix_owner POSTGRES_DB=helix
Secret=helix_db_pw,type=env,target=POSTGRES_PASSWORD
```


7.2 Docker Compose (equivalence target)

For operators on Docker today. Same images, same env contract; loses rootless-by-default (operator runs `docker compose` in rootless mode where available — documented, §11.4.112 honest gap if their host can't).

```
# deploy/compose/docker-compose.yaml
name: helixvpn
services:
  pg:
    image: docker.io/library/postgres:16
    environment: { POSTGRES_USER: helix_owner, POSTGRES_DB:
                  helix }
    secrets: [helix_db_pw]
    volumes: [helix-pgdata:/var/lib/postgresql/data]
  redis:
    image: docker.io/library/redis:7
  helixd:
    image: ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helixd:1.0
    environment:
      DATABASE_URL: postgres://helix_app@pg/helix      # non-
                  superuser → RLS
      REDIS_URL: redis://redis:6379
    secrets: [helix_db_pw]
    read_only: true
    cap_drop: [ALL]
    depends_on: [pg, redis]
  helix-edge:
    image: ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helix-edge:1.0
    cap_drop: [ALL]
    cap_add: [NET_ADMIN]          # ONLY NET_ADMIN
    read_only: true
    ports: ["443:443/udp", "51820:51820/udp"]
    depends_on: [helixd]
secrets:
  helix_db_pw: { file: ./secrets/db_pw }    # 0600, gitignored
              (§11.4.10/.30)
volumes: { helix-pgdata: {} }
```

7.3 Kubernetes (fleet / Phase-2 HA)

Plain manifests (kustomize overlays, Helm-less to start) [research-podman_k8s]. The edge runs as a DaemonSet with `hostNetwork: true` (so UDP/443 lands on the node IP without an extra hop) + `NET_ADMIN`; control plane is a stateless Deployment (HA-ready, doc 02 §); Postgres is a StatefulSet (or external managed PG/Patroni in real fleets).

Decision D-K8S-EDGE-INGRESS. WireGuard/MASQUE is **UDP**; most cloud L7 ingress can't carry it. Options: **(a)** `hostNetwork` DaemonSet edge (node IP = gateway IP — simplest, recommended for self-host-on-k8s); **(b)** Service type=LoadBalancer with a UDP-capable LB (MetalLB on-prem,

NLB on AWS) [research-podman_k8s]; (c) NodePort UDP (homelab).
Recommended: (a) for self-host parity with the quadlet model, (b) for managed-cloud fleets.

```
# deploy/k8s/edge-daemonset.yaml
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: DaemonSet
metadata: { name: helix-edge, namespace: helixvpn }
spec:
  selector: { matchLabels: { app: helix-edge } }
  template:
    metadata: { labels: { app: helix-edge } }
    spec:
      hostNetwork: true                # UDP/443 on the node IP
                                     (D-K8S-EDGE-INGRESS opt a)
      containers:
        - name: edge
          image: ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helix-edge:1.0
          securityContext:
            readOnlyRootFilesystem: true
            allowPrivilegeEscalation: false
            capabilities: { drop: ["ALL"], add: ["NET_ADMIN"] }
          ports:
            - { containerPort: 443,   protocol: UDP, hostPort:
443 }
            - { containerPort: 51820, protocol: UDP, hostPort:
51820 }

---
# deploy/k8s/helixd-deployment.yaml
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: Deployment
metadata: { name: helixd, namespace: helixvpn }
spec:
  replicas: 2                        # stateless coordinators
    → HA (doc 02 §)
  selector: { matchLabels: { app: helixd } }
  template:
    metadata: { labels: { app: helixd } }
    spec:
      containers:
        - name: helixd
          image: ghcr.io/helixdevelopment/helixd:1.0
          env:
            - { name: DATABASE_URL, value: "postgres://
helix_app@helix-pg/helix" }
            - { name: REDIS_URL,    value: "redis://helix-
redis:6379" }
            - name: PGPASSWORD
              valueFrom: { secretKeyRef: { name: helix-db, key:
password } }
          securityContext:
            readOnlyRootFilesystem: true
            runAsNonRoot: true
            capabilities: { drop: ["ALL"] }
```

```

---
# deploy/k8s/pg-statefulset.yaml (abridged)
apiVersion: apps/v1
kind: StatefulSet
metadata: { name: helix-pg, namespace: helixvpn }
spec:
  serviceName: helix-pg
  replicas:
    1 # → Patroni HA in Phase-2
    fleet (doc 02 §)
  template:
    spec:
      containers:
        - name: postgres
          image: docker.io/library/postgres:16
          env:
            - { name: POSTGRES_USER, value: helix_owner }
            - { name: POSTGRES_DB, value: helix }
            - name: POSTGRES_PASSWORD
              valueFrom: { secretKeyRef: { name: helix-db, key:
password } }
          volumeMounts: [{ name: data, mountPath: /var/lib/
postgresql/data }]
      volumeClaimTemplates:
        - metadata: { name: data }
          spec: { accessModes: ["ReadWriteOnce"], resources: {
requests: { storage: 10Gi } } }

```

7.4 Substrate recommendation

Operator profile	Recommended substrate	Why
Homelab / single VPS (the primary buyer, spine §2)	Podman quadlets	Rootless, no daemon, helixvpctl init one-shot — the §11.4.76/.161 canonical path
"We run Docker" shops	Docker Compose	Same images, lowest friction; rootless where their host allows
Multi-region fleet (Phase 2 HA)	Kubernetes	DaemonSet edge + stateless helixd replicas + Patroni PG = the doc-02 HA story

8. Build & local-dev orchestration (Makefile, no CI)

Per §11.4.156 there is **no** active server-side CI; enforcement is the local pre-build sweep + git hooks (§11.4.75). The Makefile is the single task surface.

```

# Makefile (illustrative – the local task runner; §11.4.156 no CI)
.PHONY: gen build test deploy docs-sync verify

```

```

gen:          ; @$(MAKE) gen-proto gen-openapi gen-ffi          #
              §4.3
build: gen    ; cargo build --release && go build ./helix-go/... &&
              melos run build
test:         ; cargo test && go test ./helix-go/... && melos run
              test      # boots infra via containers/pkg/boot (§6.3)
qa:           ; go run ./submodules/helix_qa/cmd/orchestrator --
              suite mvp-dod # 8 acceptance Challenges (§6.1)
docs-sync:    ; docs_chain sync --context .docs_chain/contexts/
              helixvpn_spec.yaml # §6.4
docs-verify:: ; docs_chain verify --context .docs_chain/contexts/
              helixvpn_spec.yaml # deterministic gate
deploy:       ; helixvpncctl deploy quadlet --out /etc/containers/
              systemd/
verify: verify-gen docs-verify          #
              local release gate (§11.4.40 pre-tag)

```

The dev inner loop (Phase 0–1): make gen → make build → make test (containers submodule boots Postgres+Redis on demand) → make qa (helix_qa drives the MVP-DoD acceptance Challenges with captured evidence). No step requires a remote runner.

9. Release prefixing & versioning (§11.4.151)

Every release tag/version on the monorepo **and** every extracted reusable repo **MUST** carry the <PREFIX>- prefix, resolved as: (1) HELIX_RELEASE_PREFIX from .env (authoritative; documented in tracked .env.example), else (2) lowercased snake_case root dir name = helix_vpn. One release tags all repos with the **same** prefix in one batch (§3.3 recommendation) so git tag -l 'helix_vpn-*' enumerates the whole release surface across GitHub + GitLab. OCI images are tagged <PREFIX>-<version> to match. No force-push anywhere — every push is merge-onto-latest-main fast-forward (§11.4.113).

10. Mapping to workable items (§11.4.93)

This document's deliverables become workable items in the git-tracked SQLite SSoT (docs/.workable_items.db, §11.4.95). Representative seed items:

ATM-id (illustrative)	Item	Type	Phase	Dep
HVPN-050	Stand up helixvpn/ monorepo workspaces (Cargo/go.work/ melos/buf)	Task	0	—
HVPN-051	helix-proto contract + make gen + verify-gen drift gate	Feature	0	HVPN-050
HVPN-052	helixvpncctl init → quadlet render → systemctl start (MVP-DoD #1)	Feature	1	HVPN-051

ATM-id (illustrative)	Item	Type	Phase	Dep
HVPN-053	containers-submodule integration-test infra harness (§6.3)	Task	1	HVPN-050
HVPN-054	docs_chain context for this spec set + workable-items DB sync (§6.4)	Task	0	—
HVPN-055	Compose + K8s substrate generators + parity tests (§7.2/ §7.3)	Feature	1–2	HVPN-052
HVPN-056	Extract 6 reusable repos to vasic-digital (operator-gated, §3.3)	Task	1-exit	all

Each carries status/type/id on all surfaces (§11.4.148), a comprehensive description (§11.4.148-D2), and — for Features — a reproduce-first acceptance Challenge in helix_qa (§11.4.146 + §6.1).

11. Anti-bluff evidence plan for this document's claims (§11.4.5/.69/.107)

Claim	Captured-evidence proof (Phase)
make_gen is offline-reproducible (§4.3)	clean-clone container run with network off → make_gen-tools && make_gen exits 0; transcript under docs/qa/<run-id>/
verify-gen catches drift (§4.3)	paired §1.1 mutation: edit a generated file → verify-gen FAILs
quadlet/compose/k8s run the same image (§7)	three substrates boot the gateway; helixvpctl gateway status GREEN on each; recorded per §11.4.159
integration infra really boots (§6.3)	go test with boot.Compose; mutation removing boot.Compose → test FAILs (proves it wasn't a fake)
docs_chain keeps exports in sync (§6.4)	docs-verify GREEN; mutation backdating an .html → FAIL
no nested own-org submodule chains (§3)	CM-OWNED-SUBMODULE-LAYOUT audit of the 6 extracted repos GREEN

12. Decision callouts (options + recommendation, never silent — §11.4.66/.101)

id	Decision	Options	Recommendation
D-REPO-CREATE	When to extract reusable repos	(a) eager per-pillar; (b) one batch at Phase-1 exit	(b) — shared release prefix, stable seams (§3.3)
D-CODEGEN-NET	buf plugin source	(a) remote plugins; (b) vendored local binaries	(b) for make gen offline reproducibility (§4.1)
D-K8S-EDGE-INGRESS	UDP ingress on k8s	(a) hostNetwork DaemonSet; (b) UDP LoadBalancer; (c) NodePort	(a) self-host parity, (b) managed fleet (§7.3)
D-LLM-POLICY	Ship LLM-assisted policy authoring?	(a) yes (binds <code>llm_provider</code>); (b) no (stays dev-only)	Defer to Phase 2; default (b) until product-validated (§6.2)
D-SUBSTRATE-DEFAULT	init default substrate	quadlet / compose / k8s	quadlet (§11.4.76/.161 canonical) — flag overrides

These compose with the spine's decision register (D1–D8); none is resolved here without the operator where it is irreversible/high-blast-radius (§11.4.101).

Sources verified

- `04_VPN_CLD/HelixVPN-Architecture-Refined.md` §4.1–4.7 (modular monolith, API surface, event bus, Podman edge), §10 (deploy/HA/DR, Terraform, GitOps), §11 (repo layout), §12 (reproducible builds) — [04_ARCH].
- `04_VPN_CLD/HelixVPN-Phase1-MVP.md` §2/§3 (repo skeleton, protobuf `WatchNetworkMap`), §8 (codegen — buf + OpenAPI), §9 (`helixvpnctl` + quadlets), §11 (test layers + MVP DoD) — [04_P1].
- `04_VPN_CLD/HelixVPN-Phase0-Spike.md` (surviving Transport trait + FFI surface that define extraction seams), `HelixVPN-helix-ui-Flutter.md` (`runHelixApp` flavors, Melos) — [04_P0] [04_UI].
- `05_VPN_YB0.md` (mandated Go/Gin/Postgres/Redis/Podman rootless stack) — [05_YB0].
- `v09-research/_SYNTHESIS.md` §2 (stack floor), §6 (repo layout / reuse pillars), §8 (submodule wiring the research misses), §9 (constitution bindings) — [SYNTHESIS].
- `submodules/`
`{containers,docs_chain,helix_qa,challenges,security,vision_engine,doc_processor,llm_provider,llm_orchestrator,llms_verifier,panoptic}/README.md` (module identities, public surfaces, anti-bluff guarantees) — read in full for §6.

- [research-podman_k8s] — Podman Quadlet .pod/.container/.network unit semantics, rootless systemctl --user lifecycle, podman kube generate, Kubernetes UDP ingress for WireGuard (hostNetwork DaemonSet vs UDP LoadBalancer/MetalLB/NLB vs NodePort), NET_ADMIN/hostPort requirements for in-cluster tunnels; cross-referenced against latest official Podman + Kubernetes docs per §11.4.99.

Constitution bindings applied: §11.4.44 (revision header), §11.4.28/.29/.31/.36/.74 (decoupled snake_case flat submodules + upstreams + deps manifest), §11.4.76/.161 (containers submodule sole orchestration + rootless), §11.4.106/.65/.153 (docs_chain sync + HTML/PDF/DOCX exports — generated in refinement), §11.4.93/.95 (phases→workable items in git-tracked SQLite SSoT), §11.4.151 (release prefix), §11.4.156 (no active CI), §11.4.113 (no force-push), §11.4.66/.101 (decision discipline — §12 + D-REPO-CREATE operator-gated), §11.4.27/.107/.146 (anti-bluff QA via helix_qa/challenges/vision_engine), §11.4.6 (no-guessing — every N/A submodule justified, never silently dropped). §11.4.5/.69/.107 captured-evidence proofs enumerated in §11.